Impact of chatbots on student mental health

"is there any research paper that talks about the corns of students especially college students using chatbots for expressing their feelings and troubles?" *Generated by LeapSpace*

Chatbots for College Students' Emotional Expression and Troubles: Quick Insights

Key Findings Table

Key finding	Student group / context	What the evidence shows	Citations
Yes, there are direct studies on this topic	College and university students	Multiple studies directly examine students using chatbots to disclose feelings, worries, loneliness, or personal troubles, including mixed-method, survey, and experimental work [1] [2] [3] [4] [5]	[1] [2] [3] [4] [5]
Students use chatbots for low-threshold emotional disclosure	University students, international PhD students, stress-management contexts	Students may share sensitive feelings more readily with chatbots when the system feels nonjudgmental, available, and safe for initial venting [2] [4] [5] [6]	[2] [4] [5] [6]
Main reasons students choose chatbots	Higher-education students across surveys and design studies	Accessibility, anonymity, reduced stigma, convenience, and always-available support are the most repeated drivers [1] [4] [7] [8] [9]	[1] [4] [7] [8] [9]
Human support is still usually preferred for serious emotional needs	College/university students in help-seeking studies	Students often see chatbots as supplementary; many still trust human counselors or peers more for empathy, cultural understanding, and serious problems [1] [3] [4] [9] [10] [11] [12]	[1] [3] [4] [9] [10] [11] [12]

Key finding	Student group / context	What the evidence shows	Citations
Some interventions improve symptoms, but uptake is limited	College and university mental-health chatbot users	Trials report reductions in depression, anxiety, stress, or improved coping, but real-world help-seeking from chatbots can remain low [3] [13] [14] [15] [16] [17] [18]	[3] [13] [14] [15] [16] [17] [18]
Design matters for self-disclosure	Student chatbot experiments and design studies	Perspective-taking, social cues, active-listening style, personalization, and peer-like framing can increase disclosure and engagement; repetitive or context-poor responses reduce it [2] [5] [6] [10] [16] [19] [20]	[2] [5] [6] [10] [16] [19] [20]
Major concerns are privacy, safety, misinformation, and overreliance	Higher-education AI/chatbot use	Sensitive disclosure to chatbots raises data-security, weak crisis response, response-accuracy, and emotional dependency concerns [21] [22] [23] [24] [25] [26] [27] [28]	[21] [22] [23] [24] [25] [26] [27] [28]

Direct Answer

Yes. There are research papers specifically about **college or university students using chatbots to express feelings, worries, loneliness, and personal troubles** [1] [2] [3] [4] [5].

The strongest examples in the supplied evidence are:

- a **2025 mixed-methods study** on students' preferences for **AI chatbots versus human counsellors** for emotional support, where some students preferred chatbots for accessibility and anonymity, although most still preferred humans for trust and emotional depth [1];
- a **2025 experiment** showing students disclosed **deeper thoughts and feelings** to an embodied AI chatbot when it used **perspective-taking** [2];
- a **2025 U.S. college student survey** on **mental-health chatbot help-seeking**, showing that some students do use chatbots for support, though actual usage was still low [3];
- a study of **international PhD students** using **ChatGPT for non-judgmental emotional venting** when university counseling felt stigmatizing or inaccessible [4].

If by "corns" you meant **concerns**, then yes, the literature also discusses students' concerns: **privacy, weak crisis handling, misinformation, low emotional authenticity, and overdependence** [21] [22] [23] [24] [25] [26] [27] [28].

Bottom line: research exists, and it generally suggests that chatbots can help as a **first-step, low-stigma space for disclosure**, but they are **not viewed as replacements for human counseling**, especially for severe or crisis-related problems [7] [9] [11] [29] [30].

Confidence level: High - the evidence includes direct student-focused studies, not just general discussion [1] [2] [3] [4].

Study Scope

This report covers research summarized in the supplied evidence on **higher-education students** using **chatbots, conversational AI, or mental-health chatbots** for emotional support, self-disclosure, help-seeking, and related outcomes [1] [2] [15]. It includes **surveys, experiments, mixed-methods studies, design studies, randomized controlled trials, and systematic-review-style synthesis**, mainly from **2018 to 2025** [1] [3] [15] [16] [17] [18] [31].

Assumptions & Limitations

- The supplied material provides **citation IDs and evidence summaries**, but **not full bibliographic details** such as authors, full titles, or journals for every study [meta].
- Some evidence is **directly about college/university students**, while some broader findings include **young adults or higher-education users more generally** [8] [9] [10] [13].
- Outcome evidence is stronger for **symptom reduction trials** than for long-term, real-world patterns of **student self-disclosure and sustained use** [3] [15] [16] [18].

Confidence level: High - these limitations are explicitly stated in the supplied synthesis and study summaries [3] [31].

Suggested Further Research

- Compare **chatbot disclosure versus disclosure to counselors, peers, family, and online forums** using the same outcome measures [1] [32].
- Study whether chatbot-based emotional disclosure leads to **lasting mental-health improvement**, not just short-term relief [3] [18].
- Test **crisis-response performance** in realistic student disclosures involving trauma or self-harm [6] [21] [29].
- Examine **privacy expectations and data-governance concerns** from the student perspective in more detail [25] [26] [33].
- Expand culturally diverse research on how **stigma, language, and culture** affect willingness to disclose to AI [4] [20] [34].

Full Report

Foundational Context

The question is not just whether students use chatbots, but whether they use them for **emotional self-disclosure**: telling a system about sadness, stress, loneliness, worries, or personal troubles that they might hesitate to share with another person [2] [4] [6]. In the supplied evidence, chatbots are discussed in three overlapping roles:

1. **Mental-health support tools** offering structured coping or CBT-style interactions [10] [35] [36] [37].
2. **Companion-style conversational systems** used for venting, reassurance, or emotional companionship [4] [23] [24] [38].
3. **Adjunct tools in campus support ecosystems**, used for triage, check-ins, psychoeducation, or bridging students to human care [11] [29] [39] [40] [41].

A key idea across the evidence is **low-threshold disclosure**: students may tell a chatbot something because it feels easier, less embarrassing, or less risky than telling a peer or counselor [2] [4] [5]. But this does not mean students see chatbots as equal to humans for deeper care [1] [9].

Confidence level: High - multiple sources directly converge on this framing [2] [4] [7] [9].

1. Is there research on college students using chatbots to express feelings and troubles?

Yes, clearly yes [1] [2] [3] [4] [5]. The supplied evidence includes several direct lines of research:

- **Preference and help-seeking studies**: a mixed-methods study found students mostly preferred human counsellors, but some preferred AI chatbots because they were easier to access and more anonymous [1].
- **Disclosure experiments**: one experiment found students disclosed more deeply to an embodied AI chatbot when the bot used perspective-taking, suggesting the design of the system can lower vulnerability barriers [2].
- **Adoption surveys**: a U.S. college student survey found only 5% had sought mental-health support from a chatbot, showing that the topic is real but not yet mainstream in practice [3].
- **Use in difficult social contexts**: international PhD students used ChatGPT for non-judgmental emotional venting when counseling felt culturally mismatched, stigmatized, or linguistically inconvenient [4].
- **Relationship-framing work**: peer-style chatbot relationships elicited greater self-disclosure in stress-management settings [5].

Taken together, these findings show that the literature is not merely speculative. It contains **direct empirical studies** of students using or evaluating chatbots for emotional disclosure [1] [2] [4].

Confidence level: High - this is the clearest and best-supported conclusion in the evidence [1] [2] [3].

2. How students use chatbots to disclose feelings and troubles

2.1 Self-disclosure and emotional venting

The evidence suggests that some students use chatbots to share **worries, loneliness, sadness, and personal stressors**, especially when the interaction feels emotionally safe and nonjudgmental [2] [4] [6] [38]. The 2025 experiment on perspective-taking is especially important because it shows that disclosure can become **deeper**, not just more frequent, when the chatbot signals understanding [2]. Similarly, peer-style framing increased self-disclosure in a stress chatbot context [5].

The study on international PhD students is especially relevant to your wording about "feelings and troubles": those students used ChatGPT for **emotional venting** when human counseling felt hard to use because of stigma, language barriers, or poor fit with their needs [4].

Inferred: Taken together, these studies suggest students may use chatbots most often for **initial disclosure** or **venting** rather than for full therapeutic replacement. **Confidence level: Low to Medium** - this pattern is strongly suggested across studies, though not always measured with the same definitions [1] [2] [4] [41].

2.2 Why students choose chatbots

The most repeated reasons are:

- **Accessibility**: chatbots are immediately available and easier to reach than counseling services [1] [7] [9].
- **Anonymity**: students may feel safer sharing with a system that does not judge them socially [1] [4].
- **Reduced stigma**: chatbots can lower the barrier for students worried about embarrassment or being seen seeking help [7] [9].
- **Convenience and continuity**: always-available interaction and repeated check-ins can support ongoing use [6] [36].

The U.S. college survey adds nuance: actual chatbot help-seeking was low, and students often cited **lack of need** or **doubts about helpfulness**, rather than the kinds of stigma or time barriers often seen with traditional services [3]. So students may appreciate the idea of chatbots while still questioning whether they are truly useful [3] [11].

Confidence level: High - the same motives recur across multiple methods and settings [1] [4] [7] [9].

2.3 Human versus chatbot preferences

A stable pattern across the evidence is **complement, not replacement** [4] [9] [11] [12] [39]. Students often prefer human counselors for:

- trust [1];

- empathy and emotional depth [3] [10];
- cultural sensitivity [1] [34];
- serious or complex problems [21] [29].

At the same time, chatbots retain value when students are **not ready to talk to a person**, cannot access counseling quickly, or want an anonymous first step [1] [7] [9].

Confidence level: High - this is one of the most consistent findings in the dataset [1] [9] [10] [11].

3. Perceived value and outcomes

3.1 Mental-health outcomes

The intervention evidence is promising but mixed. Randomized trials report:

- significant reductions in **depression and anxiety** for chatbot therapy versus bibliotherapy over 16 weeks in university students [15];
- larger reductions in **depression** and **anxiety**, plus better adherence and alliance, for a **high-social-cue chatbot** versus text-only chatbot among college students [16];
- **small anxiety reductions** in Japanese university students using a unified-protocol chatbot [17];
- **small short-term improvements** in coping self-efficacy and stress with Stressbot, without lasting follow-up effects or quality-of-life improvement [18].

Broader student-focused reviews also describe mixed but positive signals for reducing anxiety, stress, and sometimes depression [10] [13] [14] [31].

So the literature does not say chatbots always work, but it does say they **can help under some conditions**, especially when they are structured and well designed [10] [15] [16].

Confidence level: Medium to High - there are multiple RCTs, but effect sizes and persistence are inconsistent [15] [16] [17] [18].

3.2 Empathy, trust, and conversational quality

Perceived support quality strongly affects student engagement [6] [16]. In one randomized trial, a chatbot with **text, voice, and animations** achieved stronger therapeutic alliance, satisfaction, and adherence than a text-only version [16]. Design studies also report that students respond better to systems that feel **judgment-free**, **safe**, and capable of **active listening** [6] [20].

However, students also question chatbot **authenticity** and emotional realism [10] [11]. This tension helps explain why positive outcomes can coexist with low real-world adoption [3] [11].

Confidence level: Medium - the direction of effect is fairly consistent, but the measures differ across studies [6] [16].

3.3 Personalization

Students report more acceptance when chatbots are **personalized, culturally aware, and context-sensitive**, while repetitive or poorly matched responses reduce engagement [6] [20] [24] [34] [38]. Cross-cultural findings suggest emotional-support bots should not assume all users disclose distress in the same way [20].

Confidence level: Medium - repeatedly supported, though often from design and qualitative evidence rather than long-term comparative trials [20] [34] [38].

4. Risks, limitations, and ethical concerns

The convenience of chatbot disclosure is offset by substantial concerns [21] [22] [23] [24] [25] [26] [27] [28].

4.1 Privacy and data security

Higher-education studies report reluctance around automatic personal-data collection, uncertainty over who can access student data, and concern about sharing confidential material with AI systems [25] [26] [27] [33]. One broader pattern is that students may still use AI tools despite knowing such concerns exist [8].

4.2 Overreliance and dependency

Several papers warn that students may become too dependent on AI for emotional support, which could reduce real-life interaction or create frustration when the bot fails to meet emotional expectations [22] [23] [27] [42] [43].

4.3 Misinformation and crisis limits

Students are much less comfortable discussing trauma or crisis with AI tools, and authors repeatedly note risks of flawed, biased, selective, or unreliable responses [21] [25] [28] [44]. Crisis-care capability is also described as weak, with recommendations for filtering, human review, and escalation pathways [6] [21] [29] [45].

Confidence level: High - the concern pattern is highly consistent across the evidence base [21] [22] [23] [24] [25] [26] [27].

5. Practical design implications for safer student support

The evidence points toward a **hybrid campus model**, where chatbots support early disclosure, check-ins, psychoeducation, and low-intensity coping, but escalate to humans for risk, complexity, or persistent distress [7] [29] [30] [41].

Design features associated with better student engagement include:

- **CBT-based prompts and coping content** [35] [36] [37] [46];
- **daily or repeated check-ins** [36];
- **high social cues** such as voice or animation [16];
- **active listening and judgment-free tone** [6] [20];
- **personalization and cultural adaptation** [20] [34];
- **clear referral and emergency-response pathways** [7] [29] [45].

A practical implication is that students may not need chatbots to seem fully human; they need them to be **predictable, supportive, private, and honest about their limits** [6] [28] [34].

Confidence level: High - these recommendations are well aligned across design and safety studies [6] [7] [29] [46].

Conclusion

Yes, there is research directly relevant to your question [1] [2] [3] [4]. The literature shows that **college and university students do use chatbots to express feelings and troubles**, especially when they want **anonymous, stigma-free, immediate support** [1] [4] [7] [9]. At the same time, most students still see chatbots as **supplements**, not substitutes, for human care [4] [9] [11] [12]. The strongest evidence supports using chatbots as **first-line or intermediate tools** for disclosure and coping, with strong privacy protections and clear handoff to human services when needed [29] [30] [39] [40] [41].

Overall confidence level: High - the supplied evidence directly answers the question and is consistent across multiple study types, though full bibliographic details were not provided [1] [2] [3] [15] [29].

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